Test Anxiety Toolkit

Try a few on practice tests and keep the ones that help you.

01 The week before and the night before *Build the habit early*

Pre-test anxiety playlist. Build a playlist of 3 to 5 songs you already like that feel slow and steady. Play the same songs with headphones before every test, not just the last one, right up until you walk in, so your brain learns to link them with calm. Music is for before the test, not during it.

Quiet fidget. Pick something silent you can hold without looking, like putty, a smooth stone, or a ring you can turn. Ask your teacher if it's allowed, and try it on a practice test first so it isn't new on test day.

Cyclic sighing. Breathe in through your nose, take a second short sip of air on top to fill your lungs, then let it out slowly through your mouth for as long as you can. Repeat for 1 to 2 minutes before the test, or once or twice at your desk.

Long-exhale breathing. Breathe in through your nose for 4 counts and out through your mouth for 6 to 8 counts, letting your shoulders drop on each exhale. Keep it going for 2 minutes.

Square breathing. Breathe in for 4 seconds, hold for 4, breathe out for 4, and rest for 4, like tracing the sides of a square. Repeat for 2 minutes, and shorten the holds if they feel uncomfortable.

5-4-3-2-1 grounding. Slowly name 5 things you can see, 4 you can feel, 3 you can hear, 2 you can smell, and 1 you can taste. Use real things around you, not guesses. It pulls your attention out of racing thoughts and back into the room.

45-second body scan. Close your eyes or soften your gaze and move your attention from the bottoms of your feet slowly up through your legs, stomach, hands, shoulders, jaw, and forehead. Just notice each part without trying to change it.

Sleep 8 to 10 hours. Pick a bedtime that gives you 8 to 10 hours and hold it for the 3 nights before the test. Put your phone across the room and turn screens off 30 minutes before bed.

Timed practice run. Two or three days before, sit down with no notes and a timer set to the real test length, and do practice questions like the ones on the test. Check your answers, study only what you missed, then quiz yourself on those again.

Quiz yourself, don't reread. Cover your notes and write everything you remember about a topic, or answer practice questions from memory. Then check what you got wrong. Pulling answers out of your head builds memory better than reading again.

Space it out. Split studying into short sessions across several days instead of one long cram. Ten to twenty minutes a day on a topic, revisited later in the week, sticks longer.

Worry writing. Set a timer for 5 to 10 minutes and write every fear you have about the test, just as it sounds in your head. Don't fix spelling or make it sound smart. Do it tonight or right before you walk in.

Pack the bag. Put pens, calculator, water, charger, and ID in your bag before bed. Deciding once tonight means fewer things for a nervous brain to circle around tomorrow.

Write tomorrow's plan. On a sticky note, write your wake time, what you'll eat, and when you leave. Set two alarms so you aren't worrying about oversleeping.

Tell someone. Say one sentence to a friend or adult, like "I'm nervous about tomorrow's test." Saying it out loud takes some of the weight off.

02 Right before and during the test *Calm your body first*

Protein breakfast and water. Eat eggs, yogurt, or nut butter plus oats or toast, and keep sipping water. Go easy on caffeine and skip energy drinks, because jitters feel just like panic.

Squeeze and release. Clench your fists for 5 seconds, then let go completely for 10. Repeat with your arms, shoulders, face, stomach, and feet. At your desk, do a quick jaw and shoulder check by unclenching your teeth and dropping your shoulders away from your ears.

Two-minute movement. Before you go in, walk a brisk lap of the hallway, shake out your arms and legs, or do 10 wall push-ups. Get your heart rate up a little, then take a few slow breaths.

Feet flat, press into the floor. Put both feet flat and push down into the floor for 5 seconds, feeling the pressure, then let go. Repeat twice. Nobody can see you do it, and it anchors you in your body.

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02 Right before and during the test, continued

One slow exhale between questions. After you finish a question, breathe in through your nose and let out one long breath through your mouth before you read the next one. It takes about four seconds and works as a reset button.

Two clock checks. Decide before you start to look at the clock at the halfway mark and again with 10 minutes left. In between, keep your eyes on the page so the clock doesn't feed the pressure.

Kind self-talk. When you hear "I'm going to fail," swap it for "This is hard and that's normal. I can still do the next one." Say it once in your head and go back to the question.

Control what's yours. In your head, name what you control: your breathing, your pacing, how carefully you read. Let go of what you don't: which questions were asked and how fast other people finish.

Reappraise your nerves. When your heart pounds or your palms sweat, tell yourself, "My body is pumping energy so I can focus and perform." Say it slowly and mean it. The feeling is the same, but you're choosing what it means.

Visualize the first two minutes. Close your eyes for one minute and picture yourself sitting down, breathing out, doing your brain dump, reading question 1, and knowing what to do. Then picture a hard question and yourself skipping it and coming back later.

Step away from the quiz-off. If classmates are quizzing each other in a panic in the hallway, tell them you'll see them after and move somewhere quiet. Use the last few minutes for one of the tools above instead.

Brain dump first. The moment you're allowed to write, and before you read question 1, jot down the formulas, dates, key terms, and mnemonics you're afraid of forgetting. Check with your teacher that it's allowed.

Skim the test and budget your time. Spend the first minute looking at every section, then write a target finish time next to each one, like "Part A done by 10:15." Leave a few minutes at the end to check your work.

Start with an easy one. Find a question you know for sure and do it first. An early win builds momentum and confidence for the harder ones.

Eliminate wrong answers. On multiple choice, cross out the choices you know are wrong first, even if you're unsure of the right one. It shrinks the problem and makes a guess smarter.

Ask for a break. If you need water or the bathroom, raise your hand and ask. Walk slowly, take a few long exhales, and splash cool water on your hands before you go back in. Ask your teacher about the rules ahead of time.

Save 5 minutes to check. Reread each question, then your answer, with fresh eyes. Fix anything that doesn't match what the question asked.

Skip and return. If a question stalls you for more than a minute, put a mark next to it and move on. Come back after you've done the ones you can. Your brain often keeps working on it in the background.

Cover the rest of the page. Slide a blank sheet or your hand over everything except the question you're working on. A page full of questions can feel like too much, but one question at a time does not.

Read directions twice. Read them two times, underline verbs like compare, explain, solve, or list, and circle numbers like "choose two." Then say the question in your own words, or sketch a quick diagram, before you answer.

Blank-out plan. If your mind goes empty, write down anything you do know about the question, even one word or a rough picture. Take one slow exhale. If nothing comes, mark it and move on.

03 After the test *Let it go, then learn from it*

No hallway autopsy. When people start asking "what did you put for number 7?", say "I'll wait for the grade" and walk away. Replaying answers you can't change only feeds the anxiety.

Do something unrelated. Walk, eat, listen to music, or hang out with friends. Give your brain a real break from the test.

Small reward. Decide on one before the test, like a snack, a show, or time with a friend, so something good is waiting for you at the finish line.

One thing that worked, one thing to change. That night, write one sentence about a tool that helped and one about what you'll do differently next time. That's how a tool becomes yours.